nearly a decade that she was able to attend. Nearly 3,000 members of the NLD were in attendance for the event. In less than a week after the celebration, Suu Kyi met with Minister Aung Kyi, which culminated in the issuing of a joint statement and a press briefing. Subsequent meetings over the coming weeks confirmed that some accommodation had been ironed out. The joint memorandum spoke of all sides working together for the purpose of national development and focusing on cooperation. Overall, this sense of collaboration and trust that emerged from the meeting indicated a real change in relations between the regime and opposition.

Later in the summer of 2011, Aung San Suu Kyi spoke out openly against government repression of ethnic minorities that was increasing. To the surprise of opposition forces and the international community in general, the regime issued a statement in support of her efforts to work on behalf of resolving the ethnic problem. This change in attitude was considerably different than earlier government pronouncements, which consistently condemned any efforts of Aung San Suu Kyi to speak of matters of a political nature.

An additional breakthrough occurred when Aung San Suu Kyi was invited to Naypyidaw to meet with President Thein Sein. The visit included substantial meetings as well as workshops on economic reform that Suu Kyi attended. During the trip, Suu Kyi was also seated along side key ministers at the state dinner arranged by Sein's wife. This deliberate attempt to showcase the cooperation between Aung San Suu Kyi and the new leadership was obvious. After returning to Yangon, Suu Kyi encouraged fellow democratic advocates and former members of the NLD to believe that real change was on the horizon.

The major breakthrough in Myanmar occurred in November and December of 2011. Aung San Suu Kyi announced that the NLD would rejoin the political process. In addition, the United States moved forward in engaging the regime by sending Secretary of State Hillary Clinton to Myanmar to meet with both the leadership and with opposition leaders, including Aung San Suu Kyi. Clinton became the first U.S. Secretary of State to visit Myanmar since John Foster Dulles in 1955. The series of meetings has set the stage for future dialogue and a hope of engagement with the regime that will lead to democratic progress.